

An Investigation of Match-Up Effects in Sport Sponsorship Advertising: The Implications of Consumer Advertising Schemas

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ABSTRACT

Statistics show that sponsorship of sports and other events is one of the fastest growing areas of promotion (Ukman, 1995), but the importance of this persuasion strategy is not reflected in the amount of attention it has received in the marketing literature. Although some research has been done in this area, the majority of work has not employed the same theoretical and methodological rigor given other areas of consumer behavior (Cunningham & Taylor, 1995). Some scholars (e.g., Gwinner, 1997; Keller, 1993) have suggested that sponsorship functions like celebrity endorser advertising, where the perceived match (or mismatch) of brand attributes with the endorser's attributes influences consumer response to such marketing communications. One of the theoretical rationales used to explain matchup effects in endorser advertising is a schema-based information processing paradigm (Lynch & Schuler, 1994; Misra & Beatty, 1990). The purpose of the current study was to examine the notion that consumers possess schemas that influence their reactions to advertising leveraging sport sponsorships. The research utilizes a $3 \times 2 \times 2$ factorial design, where three variations of sport sponsorship print ads and two different magazine covers (sport and

nonsport) are used to test the influence of brand/event matchups and advertising placement on intermediate measures of advertising effectiveness. In addition to matchup and media vehicle effects, differential response by gender is also examined. Three hypotheses are tested based on research from the literature on sponsorship, matchup effects, and advertising schemas. MANOVA results provide partial support for all three hypotheses, as matchup and media vehicle manipulations were found to significantly impact A_{ad} . Moreover, females are found to report significantly higher A_{ad} and P_i than did males in this study. The advertising schema framework is used to discuss the research findings. This discussion deals with the work's applied and theoretical implications and its limitations, as well as directions for future studies on sponsorship. © 1999 John Wiley & Sons, Inc.

Corporate sponsorship is one of the fastest growing areas of promotion; however, it has yet to receive commensurate attention in the marketing research literature. One heretofore untested notion holds that sponsorship functions like celebrity endorser advertising, in that it can indirectly persuade targeted consumers by allowing a sponsor's brand to share the image of a highly regarded sport or event (Cunningham & Taylor, 1995; Gwinner, 1997; Keller, 1993). Drawing from advertising studies on celebrity endorsers and consumer advertising schemas, the current study utilizes print ads for a known brand of automobile in an experimental design that investigates differential reaction to advertising leveraging its sponsorship of three sports. In taking this approach, the study explores the potential effects of brand/sport matchups on the persuasive influence of certain sponsorship materials, as well as adding to the body of knowledge on schema-based response to marketing communications.

One reason to create a better understanding of sponsorship is that, although more and more companies are using this indirect persuasion technique, it appears that not all of them are using it effectively (Crimmins & Horn, 1996). For example, a recent editorial in an advertising industry publication speculates that fewer than 25% of major-event sponsors use this strategy to their best advantage (Heffler, 1994). A study by DDB Needham Worldwide, Chicago, supports the above contention, as only half of the Olympic sponsors tracked since 1984 (i.e., 51 of 102) were found to have made connections with consumers over a 10-year period (Crimmins & Horn, 1996). Likewise, the findings of Javalgi, Traylor, Gross, and Lampman (1994) suggest that, in certain instances, sponsorship can actually damage brand image. Consequently, an increase in sponsorship research may be useful to sponsors by helping them: (a) to select sports/event(s) that are the most appropriate for their brand's image; and (b) to create more effective advertising and promotions to leverage their sponsorships. In addition, such work can also fill

the void in the academic literature regarding how various aspects of sponsorship strategy function, from a consumer behavior perspective (Cunningham & Taylor, 1995; Gardner & Schuman, 1986; Gwinner, 1997; Javalgi et al., 1994).

Sponsorship

Sponsorship is defined here as “a cash and/or in-kind fee paid to a property . . . in return for access to the exploitable commercial potential associated with that property” (Ukman, 1995, p. 1). As such, this marketing activity may vary in terms of: (a) the nature of the sponsored property (e.g., arts, causes or sports); (b) the size and scope of its appeal (e.g., local, national or international); (c) its duration (e.g., a day, a week or a season); (d) related media coverage (e.g., live or tape delayed on broadcast or cable TV); (e) the number of sponsors involved and the level of financial commitment for each sponsor (e.g., title sponsor or official supplier); and (f) opportunities for event signage, as well as product/package tie-ins (Gardner & Schuman, 1986; Gwinner, 1997; Javalgi et al., 1994; Meenaghan, 1991; Schrieber, 1994; Ukman, 1995).

Among the reasons cited by marketers for including sponsorship as part of their marketing communications mix are such consumer-oriented objectives as building brand awareness, brand image and brand attitudes, as well as boosting sales (Crimmins & Horn, 1996; Cunningham & Taylor, 1995; Gwinner, 1997; Javalgi et al., 1994; Levin, 1993; Schrieber, 1994; Shanklin & Kuzma, 1992; Stipp & Schiavone, 1996; Ukman, 1995). Sponsorship is also used to help target consumers via their lifestyles and interests, which may indirectly improve perceptions of a sponsor's brand (Crimmins & Horn, 1996; Schrieber, 1994). Subsequently, the match or fit between a property and its sponsor becomes a matter of effectively targeting and reaching desired market segments with implicit image-related messages. If the lifestyle and/or image attributes associated with a particular sport or event are not in line with the sponsor's target markets, or the sponsorship is not appropriately leveraged, the company stands to miss its intended audience and/or fail to convey the proper message or image (Crimmins & Horn, 1996; Schrieber, 1994; Ukman, 1995).

In 1994, 4,500 companies spent approximately \$4.2 billion to acquire official sponsorship rights in North America, 67% of which went to sporting events (Ukman, 1995). The above figure does not include the additional billions spent to communicate the meaning of their sponsorships to consumers, which Crimmins and Horn (1996) argue is one of the keys to this strategy's effectiveness. Although such figures suggest corporations believe sponsorship is a viable promotional strategy, few academic researchers have studied its influence on consumer behavior; consequently, this disparity suggests it is important to develop a greater con-

ceptual understanding of sponsorship effects (Cunningham & Taylor, 1995; Gwinner, 1997; Javalgi et al., 1994; Meenaghan, 1991; Tuan Pham, 1992).

Most of the existing scholarly research on sponsorship is applied in nature and devoid of much theoretical insight regarding how it functions from a marketing communication effects perspective (Cunningham & Taylor, 1995; Gardner & Schuman, 1987; Gwinner, 1997; McDaniel & Kinney, 1996). Although some conceptual frameworks for sponsorship research appear in the literature, it has been argued that studies in this area should add more to our theoretical understanding of its influence on consumer attitudes, beliefs and behavioral intentions (Cunningham & Taylor, 1995; Kinney & McDaniel, 1996). Likewise, other marketing researchers call for similar research on how consumers perceive a brand's fit with the sport or event it sponsors (Crimmins & Horn, 1996; Gwinner, 1997; Javalgi et al., 1994; Keller, 1993).

One potential hindrance to modeling sponsorship effects may be the uncertainty of where this strategy fits in the marketing communications mix, which might subsequently influence the choice and application of an existing consumer behavior research paradigm. For example, sponsorship is noted to be strategically different from advertising in certain respects (Crimmins & Horn, 1996; Gardner & Shuman, 1987; Javalgi et al., 1994). Unlike advertising, the medium and the creative message cannot always be tightly controlled by the sponsor, as certain sponsorship materials (e.g., mediated arena signage) are not cable of communicating much, if any, information about product attributes (Pokrywczynski, 1994). Consequently, sponsorship is often seen as *indirectly* influencing consumer perceptions of the brand, whereas the traditional advertising media are associated with directly influencing consumer perception (Crimmins & Horn, 1996).

Although there are certain differences between advertising and sponsorship, it may also be argued that, as forms of marketing communication, they may be similar enough in some respects to apply models from research on the former to study the latter in terms of its consumer-oriented objectives (Cunningham & Taylor, 1995). For instance, a sponsor, like VISA, builds an entire creative platform around an event (e.g., the Olympic Games) whose organizers do not permit venue signage, thus requiring the company to use controlled messages (i.e., advertising) to leverage their association with the Games, which allows them to simultaneously communicate their contribution (e.g., financial support for American Athletes) and their product position (i.e., the card's acceptance at exclusive venues, like the Olympics). Sponsorship is also like advertising in that both are used to target consumers via their involvement with certain vehicles, and the rising use of sponsorship has recently made it more like traditional advertising media in terms of clutter levels (cf. Cunningham & Taylor, 1995; Stotlar, 1993; Tuan Pham, 1992). In addition, the similarity of their related marketing ob-

jectives suggests that the above two strategies also involve comparable consumer behaviors (e.g., in terms of information processing, affective response, and behavioral intentions). Therefore, models applied to studies of other forms of marketing communication might provide appropriate perspectives with which to initiate theory-driven research on the workings of sponsorship response (Cunningham & Taylor, 1995).

It has been posited, but never tested, that sponsorship functions like celebrity endorser advertising, in that sports and other events hold meaning for consumers that can be transferred to a sponsoring brand (Cunningham & Taylor, 1995; Gwinner, 1997; Keller, 1993). For example, Keller (1993) argues that sponsorship can help transfer a consumer's positive valence for an event property (i.e., as spectators, television viewers, or participants), toward a sponsoring brand. In order for affect transfer to occur, however, the target market needs to learn of the sponsorship (and its benefits) via exposure to concurrent advertising and promotional efforts designed to make the brand's association with the event more salient to consumers (Crimmins & Horn, 1996; Keller, 1993; Ukman, 1995). Although some sponsorship research has focused primarily on the effects of event signage (cf. Heald & McDaniel, 1994; Pokrywczynski, 1994; Tuan Pham, 1992), it is equally important to understand the persuasive influence of other types of advertising used to leverage sponsorship (Kinney & McDaniel, 1996; Tuan Pham, 1992). Based on the notion that sponsorship may function like celebrity endorser advertising (Cunningham & Taylor, 1995; Gwinner, 1997; Keller, 1993), the research literature in that area should provide an appropriate paradigm to apply in the study of brand/event relationships.

The Matchup Hypothesis and Celebrity Endorser Advertising

Unlike sponsorship, celebrity endorser advertising has received arguably greater conceptual attention from marketing scholars. Although researchers have taken slightly different theoretical and methodological approaches to investigate endorser/brand matching effects, there are several commonalties across this literature (cf. Friedman & Friedman, 1979; Kahle & Homer, 1985; Kamins, 1990; Lynch & Schuler, 1994; Misra & Beatty, 1990; Petty, Cacioppo, & Schumann, 1983). For example, the central tenet of this research stream is that advertising response is influenced by a perceived match (or similarity) between an endorser's image attributes, brand image attributes, and/or the function of a product (as moderated by product category involvement). With the use of experimental designs, these studies manipulate advertised endorser/brand relationships by varying such attributes as levels of endorser attractiveness and likability, as well as the degree of consumer involvement with products (cf. Friedman & Friedman, 1979; Kahle & Homer, 1985; Kamins, 1990; Lynch & Schuler, 1994; Misra & Beatty, 1990; Petty et al., 1983).

Among the key findings in this area, attitude toward the ad (A_{ad}) (Kamins, 1990), brand attitude (A_b) (Friedman & Friedman, 1979; Kahle & Homer, 1985; Kamins, 1990; Misra & Beatty, 1990; Petty et al., 1983) and purchase intentions (PI) (Friedman & Friedman, 1979; Kahle & Homer, 1985) have all been found to be significantly related to the perceived fit of an endorser's attributes (e.g., likability) with those of the brand (in low-involvement conditions). In addition to involvement and matching effects, gender has also been shown to be a significant influence in certain studies (Kahle & Homer, 1985). Although the so-called matchup paradigm has proven a fruitful line of inquiry, one of the limitations across this body of work is that researchers have generally neglected to report variance explained; consequently, this issue needs to be addressed, in order to ascertain the extent to which the matchup phenomenon impacts the persuasion process.

One of the implicit principles in the matchup hypothesis is that consumers have memory-based expectations of the attributes embodied by celebrities, brands, and product categories, which subsequently influence reactions to endorser advertising (Lynch & Schuler, 1994; Misra & Beatty, 1990; Speck, Schumann, & Thompson, 1988). According to Wright (1986), many theories in advertising and marketing research often neglect the possibility that consumers develop their own theories about the structure and purpose of marketing communications. This intuitive knowledge, or advertising schema, can influence selective attention, perception, and response to advertising (Wright, 1986). Therefore, given the parallels noted between sponsorship and celebrity endorser advertising (Keller, 1993) and the use of schema theory to study the latter (Lynch & Schuler, 1994; Misra & Beatty, 1990), the ad-schema paradigm might provide the conceptual underpinnings for explaining matchup effects in sponsorship advertising as well.

Advertising Schemas

The notion of advertising schemas is an emerging stream of marketing research, which holds that people efficiently process new advertising stimuli by comparing it to memories of prototypic ads (Goodstein, 1993; Goodstein, Moore, & Cours, 1992; Stoltman, 1990; Wright, 1986). A schema is a hypothetical cognitive structure that guides perception, thought and action based on prior knowledge of stimuli gained through experience, media exposure, etc. According to Speck et al. (1988), "schemas organize perception by organizing expectation [based on prior knowledge] (p. 70)." One of the key features of a schema is its ability to cue affective and behavioral response to stimuli, such as advertising (Fiske & Linville, 1980; Stoltman, 1990).

In this paradigm, consumers process marketing communications by matching visual and contextual cues from an advertisement (and possibly the media vehicle where it appears) to their prior knowledge of

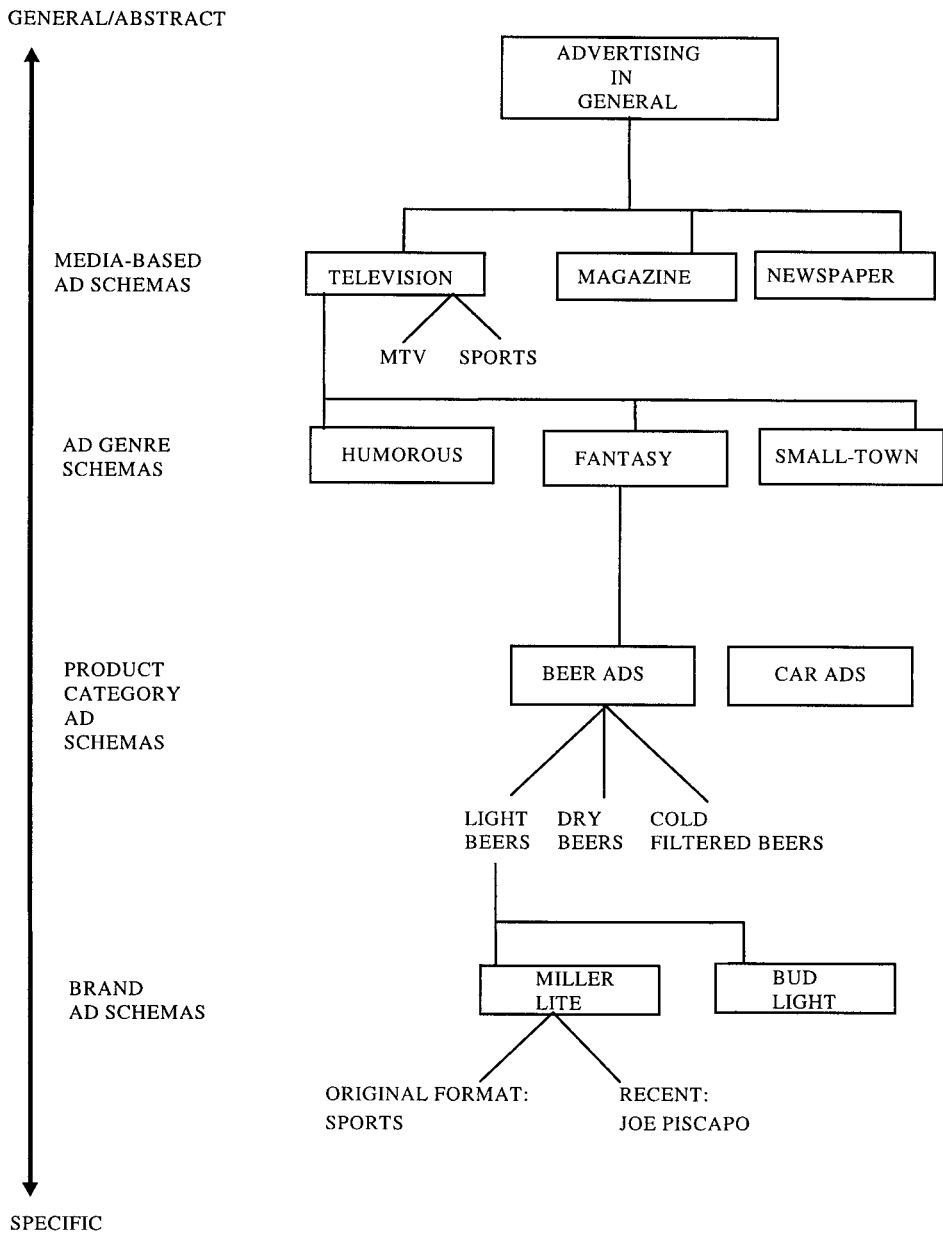


Figure 1 Levels of abstraction for ad schemas (Stoltman, 1990).

similar stimuli stored in the appropriate schema (Goodstein, 1993; Goodstein et al., 1992; Stoltman, 1990; Wright, 1986). Advertising schemas are argued to operate at a number of levels, as illustrated by the now-dated advertising examples contained in Figure 1, which are taken from Stoltman (1990). According to his diagram, the perceiver's selective attention to a particular level(s) is activated by the ad cues that are most salient to him or her. Research findings in this area suggest that

consumers' expectations of advertising, contained in advertising schemas, can influence their attitudes and behavioral intentions toward advertised brands and their marketing communications (Goodstein, 1993; Goodstein et al., 1992). In addition, schematic memory holds other elements that can also influence advertising response, including knowledge of product categories (Sujan, 1985), brands, and endorsers (Lynch & Schuler, 1994; Misra & Beatty, 1990; Speck et al., 1988).

Stoltman (1990) posits that advertising schemas develop in much the same way as other schemas, through repetitive exposure to a stimulus category. Because advertising involves certain conventions in terms of structure and content, he argues that repeated exposure creates consumer expectations of advertising in relation to the various executional elements, for example, product category, brand, format, and media vehicle (Stoltman, 1990). Among the pertinent areas of inquiry in this area, according to Stoltman (1990), are the potential influence of the advertising media vehicle on perceived schema congruence (i.e., matching), as well possible differences in ad schemas and related responses across various consumer segments (e.g., male or female audiences).

Sport or event sponsorships are used to target consumers who value a sponsored property, for example, the Olympics (Crimmins & Horn, 1996; Schrieber, 1994). Consequently, these audiences are likely to have well-developed schemas related to special events, from attending them in person and/or viewing them on television. Such schemas might also contain product categories that are typically part of fans' sport or event experience (e.g., beer or snack foods). As part of their event schemas, consumers may also acquire sponsorship memory structures that contain brands or product categories that they come to associate as traditional sponsors through repeated exposure to arena signage or other sponsorship-related promotions over time. Therefore, it is possible that event schemas create different expectations, in terms of the conventions people connect with various sponsorships. Moreover, these memory structures are likely to vary across consumer segments, in terms of their content and associated affective response (e.g., although a sport such as bowling might hold positive meanings for certain groups, it may also hold negative connotations for others). Consequently, event schemas could influence the processing and response to advertising used to leverage sponsorship (which is often the main source of sponsorship information for consumers, when it comes to certain major events or sports, such as the Olympics).

Figure 2 shows a modified version of Stoltman's (1990) ad-schema topology, which substitutes sport sponsorship (for Toyota Celica) as an ad genre schema. Following Stoltman's rationale, this schema type may be activated from a print ad's cues, such as a visual and/or textual reference to certain sporting events, athletes, team or league logos, along with direct mention of the brand being an official sponsor of one or the

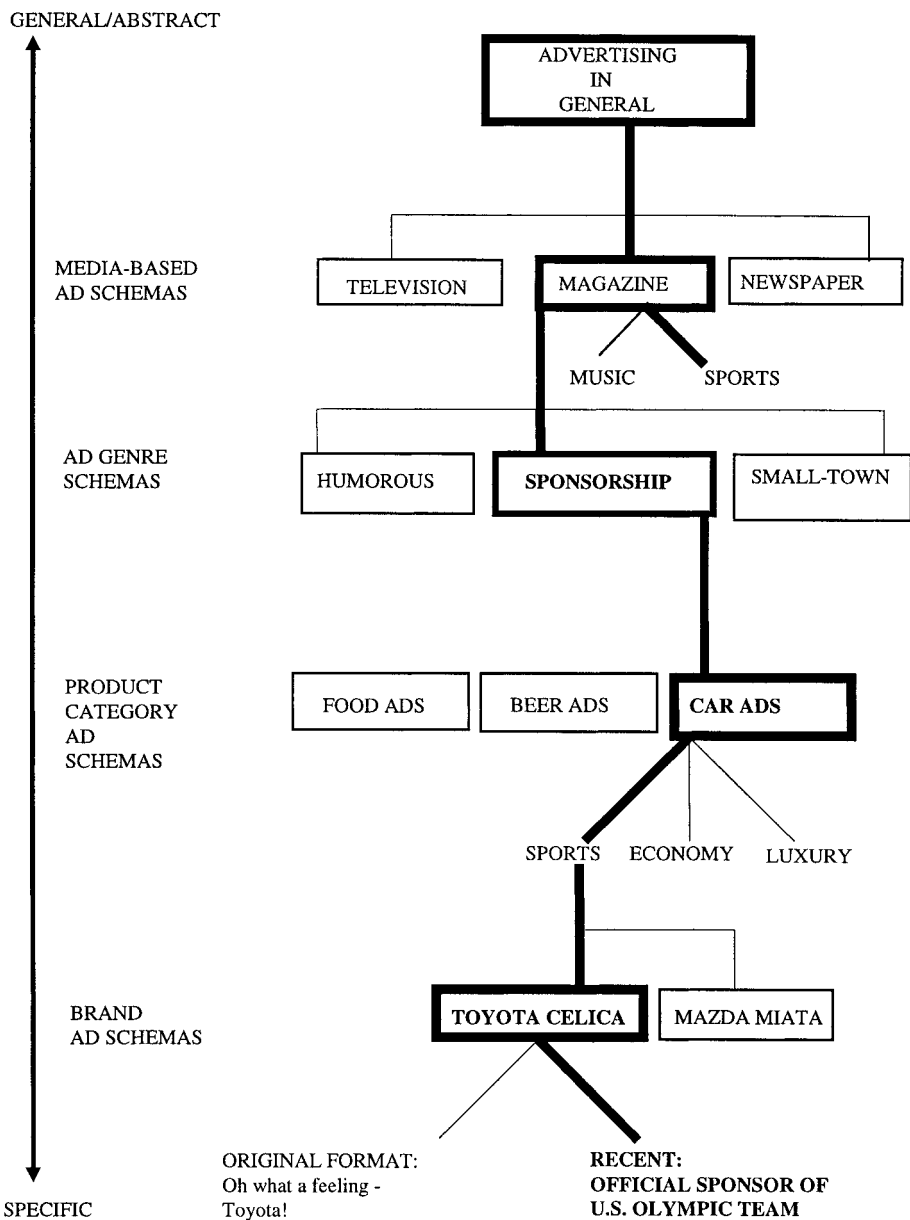


Figure 2 Modified levels of abstraction featuring activated sponsorship ad schema (based on Stoltman, 1990).

other. All of this may serve to activate product category and brand ad schemas (or vice versa). The sponsorship ad schema may also be cued by the ad's context, depending on the media vehicle in which it appears (e.g., *Sports Illustrated*). It seems plausible (although untested) that contextual elements in sponsorship ad executions may cue memory-

based expectations that, moderated by product category and event involvement, influence consumer response to what Crimmins and Horn (1996) classify as an indirect form of persuasion.

Involvement

As previously noted, the involvement construct is central to the study of sponsorship because of the strategy's focus on consumer lifestyles (Schrieber, 1994). Involvement is an important variable in modeling consumer advertising response, and it has been characterized in the literature as either a trait, state, or process (Muehling, Lacznia, & Andrews, 1993). Although researchers disagree on the definitive nature of the construct, involvement is often conceptualized as a motivational state that moderates processing based on its cognitive and affective dimensions (Park & Mittal, 1985; Zaichkowsky, 1994). According to the sponsorship literature, consumer involvement with promotional materials, like event signage, may result from the situational arousal associated with the sponsored property, as well as its enduring personal relevance to the consumer (Heald & McDaniel, 1994; Tuan Pham, 1992). Crimmins and Horn (1996) draw upon Heider (1946) to argue that, by linking a highly valued object (e.g., a sporting event) with an object of equal or lesser value (i.e., the sponsor's brand), sponsorship creates a balance between the two objects that can indirectly foster positive beliefs about a sponsor in the minds of consumers. Therefore, it seems likely that involvement with both products and events functions to shape consumer's memory-based expectations and subsequent response to various sponsorship materials (Gwinner, 1997; Heald & McDaniel, 1994; Tuan Pham, 1992).

Based on the elaboration likelihood model (ELM) of persuasion (Petty et al., 1983), where product category involvement moderates ad stimuli involvement, some posit that sponsorship acts a peripheral cue and is subsequently most effective for low-involvement products (Gwinner, 1997; Pokrywczynski, 1994; Sandler & Shani, 1989). However, Ukman (1995) notes that an increasing number of brands in high-involvement categories have become involved in sponsorship, with at least 30% of all sponsorship activity involving such companies (i.e., automotive, financial services, information services, and travel). Consequently, Cunningham and Taylor (1995) suggest that sponsorship might also be effective for high-involvement products, as it could be perceived as a value-added product attribute (which would also seem to have important implications in terms of matchup effects, that is, the matching of product/brand and event attributes). To date the effects of the relationship between product category and event involvement remain relatively unexplored (Gwinner, 1997).

Gender Effects and Sponsorship

As with research on endorser advertising and advertising schemas, the influence of gender has also been noted as an important area of investigation in consumer response to sport marketing (Burnett, Menon, & Smart, 1993; Shani, Sandler, & Long 1992; Tuan Pham, 1992). For example, Tuan Pham (1992) finds that males have significantly higher sponsor recall than do females. Likewise, Burnett et al. (1993) find lifestyle, attitudinal, and media usage differences in males and females. Studies also find that females tend to process information differently (Meyers-Levy, 1988) and to react more positively than males toward firms that sponsor social causes (Ross, Patterson, & Stutts, 1992). Although the sponsorship of causes is argued to differ strategically from the sponsoring of events (Javalgi et al., 1994), it may be that consumers respond to both in a similar fashion (Cunningham & Taylor, 1995). Much like the questions surrounding involvement effects, however, potential gender-based response differences also represent a relatively unexplored area of sponsorship research (Shani et al., 1992; Tuan Pham, 1992).

In summary, despite the growing use of sponsorship, little is known in terms of how this strategy functions from a consumer-behavior perspective (Cunningham & Taylor, 1995; Gwinner, 1997; Meenaghan, 1991). It has been hypothesized that sponsorship is similar to endorser advertising, where the perceived fit between the image of the sponsor and the image of the event influences consumer response (Gwinner, 1997; Keller, 1993). In addition to research on matching effects, others have called for sponsorship research that explores: the influence of involvement (Gwinner, 1997; Heald & McDaniel, 1994; Tuan Pham, 1992); the executional elements involved in the leveraging of sport marketing materials, like sponsorship advertising (Kinney & McDaniel, 1996; Burnett et al., 1993); as well as potential gender-based response differentials (Burnett et al., 1993; Shani et al., 1992; Tuan Pham, 1992). Because of their successful application in the study of a similar phenomenon (i.e., endorser advertising) (cf. Lynch & Schuler, 1994; Misra & Beatty, 1990; Speck et al., 1988), schema-based information processing models (e.g., Stoltman, 1990) offer a good deal of face validity to investigate the above questions regarding sponsorship.

Based on the preceding review of literature on sponsorship, celebrity endorser advertising, and advertising schemas, the following hypotheses were formulated:

- H₁:** If subjects' existing A_b is controlled for, their A_{ad} , posttest A_b , and P_i for the sponsor brand will significantly differ, based on the sport sponsorship depicted in their assigned ad treatment ($p < .05$).

- H₂:** If subjects' existing A_b is controlled for, their A_{ad} , posttest A_b , and P_i for the sponsor brand will significantly differ based on the particular magazine in which the sport sponsorship ad treatment appears ($p < .05$).
- H₃:** If subjects' existing A_b is controlled for, their A_{ad} , posttest A_b , and P_i for a sport sponsor will significantly differ based on their gender ($p < .05$).

METHOD

The experimental method and operationalization of variables in this study were designed to be consistent with the marketing communication literature on the matchup phenomenon in celebrity endorser advertising (cf. Friedman & Friedman, 1979; Kahle & Homer, 1985; Kamins, 1990; Lynch & Schuler, 1994; Misra & Beatty, 1990). Consequently, the current research contained two phases: (a) initial data collection to facilitate stimulus construction, and (b) a main phase of data collection used to test the study's hypotheses.

Prior to constructing the advertising treatments, a convenience sample of 32 undergraduate communication students ranked a short list of product categories known to use sponsorship. Respondents were instructed to rank products based on their personal relevance, along with reporting a favorite and least-favorite brand in each category. The subjects also ranked ten major sports and events according to their interest in them. Finally, the students completed a series of 7-point semantic-differential scales to gauge their perceptions of image attributes for each brand and event listed. The six items used in the image attribute scales were taken from a study by Sadalla, Linder, and Jenkins (1988) that examined students' perceptions of image dimensions for various sports.

Based on the results from the preliminary image data, three treatment ads were laid out by a professional graphic artist to depict fictional sponsorship relationships between a known brand of automobile and three different sports (i.e., PBA Bowler's Tour, NHL hockey, and the Olympics). The sports included in the sponsorship ads were chosen because they represented three contrasting levels of sport involvement and image attributes to the college-age audience at the university where the study took place. The black-and-white tombstone ads employed in the study were constructed to look as similar as possible in terms of layout and typeface. The copy, however, varied across ads, as the text in each execution was developed around the featured sponsorship in an attempt to cue memory for that sport—similar to other schema-based research on matching effects (cf. Misra & Beatty, 1990).

A known brand of automobile was employed in the current study for several reasons. First, it was important that subjects be familiar with the brand in order to increase ecological validity, because sponsorship

tends to be a strategy employed by mature brands; therefore, sponsorship research employing a fictional or unknown brand would have little applied value. Likewise, it was important to choose a brand (and events) for which subjects had well-developed schematic memories. Finally, the automobile represents a high-involvement stimulus object from a product category that accounts for 8% of all event sponsorships (Ukman, 1995); this facilitates the testing of sponsorship effects for high-involvement products (Cunningham & Taylor, 1995).

Advertisements were bound in treatment booklets containing two pages of instructions followed by a black-and-white photocopy of a magazine cover (either *Sports Illustrated* or *Spin*). The two covers suggest contrasting content (i.e., sports and music, respectively) but are both popular among the college demographic comprising the sample. This allows for the valid testing of the notion that ad schemas can be cued by the media vehicle in which an ad appears (Goodstein et al., 1992; Stoltman, 1990). The ad treatment variations were embedded in the booklets along with three dummy ads, taken from a recent edition of *Sports Illustrated*, similar in design and photocopied in black and white to be consistent with the ads constructed for this study. Each dummy ad was placed at a fixed point, whereas placement of the treatment ads differed across booklets to control for any ordering effects. The treatments were such that each subject received exposure to only one of the automobile ads (i.e., an ad featuring a sponsorship for either the PBA Bowler's Tour, NHL hockey, or the Olympics).

The main phase of data collection consisted of a convenience sample of 216 undergraduates (89 males and 127 females), from the Colleges of Business and Communication at a large southeastern university. In most cases, respondents volunteered to participate in the study in exchange for receiving extra-credit points in their introductory marketing and mass communication courses.

The study utilized a pretest/posttest design, with randomized distribution of treatment booklets. Subjects sat apart from one another but participated simultaneously in groups ranging in size from 15 to 45, with participants being instructed not to communicate with or observe the work of others (cf. Kahle & Homer, 1985; Kamins, 1990). Prior to receiving their ad booklets, each group completed pretest involvement and attitudinal measures. They were informed that they were reviewing advertising prototypes being considered for upcoming promotional campaigns. Posttest measures were administered once subjects had reviewed their ad booklets. The entire data collection procedure took approximately 35 min for them to complete.

The 7-point semantic-differential scales used in the main portion of this study were taken from relevant marketing literature and adjusted where necessary to fit the research context. For example, pretest levels of product category and sporting-event involvement were gathered as a manipulation check, with the use of the Zaichowsky (1994) 10-item in-

volvement inventory. To control for existing brand attitudes, the pretest also contained a 3-item A_b scale, based on Muehling and Laczniak (1988). The posttest instrument included measures for three dependent variables: (a) an 8-item A_{ad} scale (Machleit & Wilson, 1988); (b) the 3-item A_b scale mentioned above; and (c) a 3-item P_i scale (Machleit & Wilson, 1988). All of the measures employed in this study, including the matchup manipulation checks, exhibited reliability equal to, or above, the Cronbach alphas reported in the literature from which they were taken, with coefficients ranging from 0.94 to 0.97.

RESULTS

Manipulation Checks

The sponsorship advertising manipulations employed in this study are based largely on subjects' involvement with (and the perceived image of) three featured sports leagues/events. Because the involvement construct has an important affective dimension (Park & Mittal, 1985; Zaichkowsky, 1994), its use here can be seen as similar to studies on celebrity endorser advertising that manipulate the likability of featured endorsers (cf. Kahle & Homer, 1985). Therefore, it is important to demonstrate that each sponsorship ad condition represents a different mean level of involvement, while showing that there are no confounds in terms of any pretest gender X sport and/or gender X product category differences in those measures.

The single-sample *t*-test results in Table 1 suggest that the three sporting events selected for inclusion in the study's three ad manipulations achieved the desired levels of contrast in terms of subjects' mean involvement with each. In addition, a one-way analysis of variance procedure (ANOVA) reveals that the only statistically significant ($df = 1$; $F = 5.45$; $p < .05$) pretest differences in stimulus involvement by gender is associated with NHL hockey, as males (4.45) report significantly greater involvement with that sport than do females (3.99). This difference could account for the existence of certain main effects found during testing the hypotheses on gender differences, if gender X ad interaction effects are detected. Lastly, it should be noted that the tabled *t*-test results illustrate that subjects were highly involved in the product category under study, which is a feature of this study that extends previous research on both matchup and sport sponsorship phenomena (which typically employ low-involvement products).

As part of the posttest, subjects completed a series of 7-point Likert scales that were used to measure the degree to which subjects perceived a holistic match between the theme of each sponsorship ad, the brand, and the product category, similar to Misra and Beatty (1990). The six

Table 1. Analysis of Variance for Pretest Stimulus Involvement Levels by Gender

Stimulus Object	Gender	Mean Involvement Level	<i>df</i>	<i>F</i>	Difference from Scale Midpoint	<i>df</i>	<i>t</i>
Product category	Males	5.41 (<i>SD</i> = 1.18)	1	3.89	+1.41 ^b	88	11.12
	Females	5.11 (<i>SD</i> = .98)			+1.11 ^b	126	12.77
PBA bowling	Males	2.00 (<i>SD</i> = 1.21)	1	0.04	-2.00 ^b	89	-17.30
	Females	2.00 (<i>SD</i> = 1.11)			-2.00 ^b	127	-19.19
NHL hockey	Males	4.45 ^a (<i>SD</i> = 1.64)	1	4.00	0.45 ^c	88	2.57
	Females	3.99 ^a (<i>SD</i> = 1.64)			0.01	127	-0.03
U.S. Olympic team	Males	5.73 (<i>SD</i> = 1.27)	1	0.00	+1.73 ^b	87	12.68
	Females	5.69 (<i>SD</i> = 1.37)			+1.69 ^b	126	13.82

Note: Involvement levels reported for the particular sports and product category employed here are reflective of the student population used in this study and may vary among other populations (due to any combination of demographic, geographic, and psychographic influences).

^aSignificantly different by gender: $p < .05$.

^bAggregate mean difference from involvement scale midpoint: $p < .000$.

^cAggregate mean difference from involvement scale midpoint: $p < .05$.

items were then summed and averaged to create an index, where the scale midpoint of 4 is the threshold value for a match or mismatch. ANOVA results support that the sponsorship manipulations were perceived as intended, as a post hoc Bonferroni technique detected statistically significant differences ($df = 2$; $F = 6.60$; $p < .05$) between the mean matchup score (3.61, $SD = 1.7$) for the advertisement featuring Toyota's sponsorship of the PBA bowler's tour (i.e., the low-involvement sponsorship condition) and the mean score (4.64, $SD = 1.4$) for the advertisement featuring their sponsorship of the U.S. Olympic team (i.e., the high-involvement sponsorship condition). The mean matchup score (4.22, $SD = 1.6$) for the ad featuring the NHL sponsorship was not found to be significantly different from the other sponsorship ads, which helps support its use as a neutral matchup condition.

Attitudes and Purchase Intentions

Given the strong relationship between the study's three dependent variables and the need to control testing error, the hypotheses were tested using a $3 \times 2 (\times 2)$ factorial multiple analysis of variance (MANOVA) procedure, with gender as a status variable and pretest A_b as a covariate (cf. Kamins, 1990). As would be expected for a known brand, the results indicate that the covariate, pretest A_b , has a statistically significant influence ($p < .005$) across all three dependent variables. This measure

Table 2. Multiple Analysis of Variance for Sport/Sponsor Matching Effects

Dependent Variables	DF	Adjusted Means by Ad Treatment Group			F	η^2
		PBA Bowling	NHL Hockey	U.S. Olympic Team		
Attitude toward ad	2	3.99 ^a	4.30 ^a	4.82 ^a	7.12*	0.06
Posttest brand attitude		5.54	5.44	5.45	0.33	
Purchase intentions		4.86	4.62	4.77	0.54	

Note: Wilks's lambda multivariate test significant at $p < .00$.

^aSignificantly different at $p < .05$, adjusted for pretest brand attitude (post hoc Bonferroni test).

* $p < .00$.

accounts for a large part of the variance explained in both posttest A_b ($\eta^2 = 0.65$) and Pi ($\eta^2 = 0.43$).

Matching Effects

The main effects from the MANOVA results for the first hypothesis can be found in Table 2. The tests of H_1 result in partial support of the research hypothesis, with A_{ad} found to be a statistically significant ($p < .05$) function of matchup manipulations (controlling for pretest A_b). Post hoc tests show that adjusted mean A_{ad} in the Olympic sponsorship condition is significantly greater than either the NHL hockey or PBA bowling conditions. As might be expected with a single ad exposure for an existing brand, no significant treatment effects are evidenced in posttest A_b or Pi measures. It should be noted that the matchup manipulation accounts for more variance in A_{ad} ($\eta^2 = 0.06$) than did pretest A_b ($\eta^2 = 0.03$), with adjusted mean A_{ad} scores following a pattern similar to the involvement and matchup manipulation checks reported earlier. No statistically significant interactions were detected between the ad manipulations and any of the other variables analyzed.

Media Vehicle Effects

The MANOVA results for H_2 appear in Table 3. They indicate that, if pretest A_b was controlled for there was a significant ($p < .05$) treatment effect in terms of the influence of ad placement on A_{ad} , which partially supports the research hypothesis. Adjusted mean A_{ad} scores for sponsorship advertising in the *Sports Illustrated* treatment condition are significantly greater than the same measures for sponsorship advertising in the *Spin* treatment condition. The magazine cover treatments explain a modest 3% of the variance in A_{ad} ($\eta^2 = 0.03$). Although posttest A_b is slightly higher in the sport magazine condition, the media vehicle manipulation accounts for no statistically significant difference

Table 3. Multiple Analysis of Variance for Media Vehicle Effects

Dependent Variables	Adjusted Means by Media Vehicle Treatment				
	<i>DF</i>	<i>Spin</i>	<i>Sports Illustrated</i>	<i>F</i>	η^2
Attitude toward ad	1	4.15 ^a	4.60 ^a	5.56*	0.03
Posttest brand attitude		5.40	5.56	2.40	
Purchase intentions		4.84	4.65	1.11	

Note: Wilks's lambda multivariate test significant at $p < .05$.
*Significantly different at $p < .05$, adjusted for pretest brand attitude (post hoc Bonferroni test).
* $p < .05$.

in it or in adjusted mean Pi measures, nor were any significant interaction effects found involving that variable.

Gender Effects

The third and final hypothesis appears to receive the study's strongest support, according to the results found in Table 4. Pretest A_b is controlled for, A_{ad} and Pi response measures are found to be significantly ($p < .05$) different by gender, with females reporting significantly higher adjusted means than males for both of the above constructs. The gender variable has no statistically significant impact in terms of posttest A_b , however, and does not interact with any of the other variables. It subsequently accounts for 3% of the variance explained ($\eta^2 = .03$) in both A_{ad} and Pi measures.

Discussion

Although the three research hypotheses are not fully supported across all the dependent variables, the results still have potentially significant applied and theoretical implications. In terms of the applied aspects of the research, findings lend support to the intuitive notion that matching a brand/product to a sport or a special event can positively impact sponsorship response within a particular market segment. Moreover, media vehicle selection (e.g., ad placement in a sport versus nonsport maga-

Table 4. Multiple Analysis of Variance for Gender Effects

Dependent Variables	Adjusted Means by Gender				
	<i>DF</i>	Males	Females	<i>F</i>	η^2
Attitude toward ad	1	4.14 ^a	4.60 ^a	5.36*	0.03
Posttest brand attitude		5.42	5.54	1.08	
Purchase intentions		4.52 ^a	4.97 ^a	5.18*	0.03

Note: Wilks's lambda multivariate test significant at $p < .05$.
*Significantly different at $p < .05$, adjusted for pretest brand attitude (post hoc Bonferroni test).
* $p < .05$.

zine) may also play a part in how consumers react to this type of marketing communication, based on their sponsorship advertising schemas. Although effects of matchup and media vehicle manipulations were only detected for A_{ad} scores (after one exposure), these factors may have implications on brand choice over time given the moderating influence of A_{ad} on A_b and P_i (cf. Mackenzie, Lutz, & Belch, 1986), although a replication of the current study with a longitudinal design is necessary to sufficiently test this notion. If true, however, it suggests that potential sponsors should use research to gain an understanding of their target markets' brand and event schemas prior to investing in sponsorships, as well as working to run ads that leverage their sponsorships in appropriate media vehicles.

The influence of gender on sponsorship response should also be of potential interest to sponsorship practitioners. From an applied standpoint, the impact of gender in this study appears to be counterintuitive, given that sports audiences are often male dominated; conversely, the women in this study report significantly more positive reactions to sport sponsorship ads than do men, despite showing no significant pretest differences in stimulus involvement that might otherwise account for such a response (see Table 1). Future research should continue to examine gender-based response differentials across a variety of events to learn more about the implications of using sponsorship to target women (Shani et al., 1992).

In addition to the study's applied implications, the influence of matchup, media vehicle manipulations, and gender effects offer important conceptual considerations as well. For example, it appears that consumers may indeed have memory-based expectations of advertised brand/sport relationships, as well as expectations of where sponsorship advertising should appear. Both of these findings are consistent with the literature on consumer advertising schemas (cf. Goodstein, 1993; Goodstein et al., 1992; Lynch & Schuler, 1994; Misra & Beatty, 1990; Stoltman, 1990; Wright, 1986). Moreover, given the significant difference between mean A_{ad} reported across the three sport sponsorship treatment conditions, it is possible that this strategy is similar to endorser advertising, as previously suggested in the marketing literature (cf. Gwinner, 1997; Kamins, 1990; Keller, 1993). However, given the relatively low amount of variance explained by match-up manipulations for the high involvement product category in this study, more research needs to be done across involvement levels before any firm conclusions can be drawn regarding the persuasive effects of the match-up phenomenon.

The differences in sponsorship advertising response by gender appears consistent with existing research on gender differences in both information processing (cf. Meyers-Levy, 1988) and cause-related marketing (Ross et al., 1992). According to that literature, women tend to be more positively valenced toward firms that support social causes

(Meyers-Levy, 1988; Ross et al., 1992). Likewise, even after controlling for their pretest A_b , the female subjects in the current study reported more favorable responses toward sponsorship advertising than did their male counterparts, as suggested by their significantly higher A_{ad} and P_i scores. The aforementioned sponsorship response differential may also be explained by the notion that advertising memory structures vary between audience segments (Stoltman, 1990).

Finally, in order to give context to the study's findings, it is important to note its methodological limitations. Although the homogenous nature of the student sample facilitated a valid comparison across treatment groups, the generalizability of findings are limited, given both the convenience sample and its unbalanced composition in terms of gender, as well as the artificial exposure conditions and the particular sports and product category examined. Moreover, because status variables like gender cannot truly be randomized, it is possible that the related findings may be due to the effects of a lurking variable that was not controlled for by the covariate or manipulation checks employed here (Hair, Anderson, Tatham, & Black, 1995). Future sponsorship research should include a wider variety of marketing stimuli (i.e., products, brands, and events) to examine response across diverse demographic and psychographic segments, as well as work to find alternative explanations for potential gender differences in sponsorship response similar to those reported here.

Although the research design and measures employed herein did parallel previous schema-based research on matchup effects (cf. Lynch & Schuler, 1994; Misra & Beatty, 1990), a more varied approach to data collection (e.g., thought listings) is also needed to fully support the existence of the hypothesized sponsorship schema framework (see Figure 2) and its content (Stoltman, 1990). Likewise, by paralleling designs used in most endorser advertising research (where the effects of endorser ads are not compared to effects of ads without endorsers), the study investigates certain sponsorship effects but not true sponsorship effectiveness (cf. Friedman & Friedman, 1979; Kahle & Homer, 1985; Kamins, 1990; Lynch & Schuler, 1994; Misra & Beatty, 1990). Consequently, it is also important for replications of this work to employ designs that allow testing the effectiveness of sponsorship to other forms of marketing communication by using advertising referencing an event sponsorship, so-called ambush advertising using event-related images (with no references to official sponsorship), and event-neutral advertising.

CONCLUSION

The current study represents the first known effort to examine matchup effects in the realm of sponsorship advertising (Cunningham & Taylor,

1995; Gwinner, 1997; Keller, 1993). Moreover, it advances the sponsorship literature by using theoretical constructs (e.g., involvement) and theoretical rationale (i.e., schema theory) to examine this persuasion technique from a consumer-behavior perspective, with the use of a high-involvement product (Cunningham & Taylor, 1995). In addition to adding to the sponsorship literature, the research also helps to advance the matchup literature by reporting variance explained by that phenomenon, and its focus on gender and media vehicle effects also contributes to the body of work on consumer advertising schemas.

Given the lack of research on sponsorship, there is much left to examine in this area. Although the current study suggests that matching brands to sports may influence consumer response to sport sponsorship advertising, it does not necessarily imply that sponsorship meets consumer-oriented marketing objectives. It is therefore important for sport marketing researchers to continue balancing applied and theoretical concerns. Perhaps the notion of sponsorship advertising schemas offered here is an appropriate framework with which to pursue further conceptually grounded research in this growing area of marketing communication.

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